

On the fast lane: Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's (facing page) elevation doesn't diminish his credentials, but it does reflect how the conversation around selection has evolved. **Right and below:** Ruturaj Gaikwad and Rajat Patidar, captains of West Zone and defending champion Central Zone, are among the other rising names in the domestic circuit. AFP & K. MURALI KUMAR

among the contenders, while seasoned campaigners such as Shardul Thakur have an opportunity to push for a comeback. With the selectors also investing in youngsters such as Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, it is a chance for the experienced players to stamp their class across for mats.

There was a time when the route to the Test team seemed almost predictable. A prolific Ranji Trophy season earned a place in the Duleep Trophy. Success there led to India A. A good India A tour often resulted in an India cap.

That isn't quite how it works anymore.

These days, the selectors weigh domestic performances alongside India A tours, overseas assignments, fitness reports, workload management, technical assessments and long-term planning. The IPL has also become an important scouting platform, particularly for identifying players with exceptional upside.

The Duleep Trophy has also thrown up some interesting stories over the years. In 1991, two teenagers made their debuts against each other in Guwahati - Sachin Tendulkar, 17, scoring 159 for West Zone and Sourav Ganguly an unbeaten 124 for East Zone. Both would go on to become India greats.

Irfan Pathan's breakthrough came through the tournament too. He took 22 wickets in the 2002 edition and 19 the following year before making his India debut on the 2003-04 Australia tour. Yuvraj Singh's 208 in the 2003 final was another statement, followed by his Test debut weeks later.

VVS Laxman's 121 in the 1995-96



semifinal was an important step towards his India call-up, while Jasprit Bumrah's 2014 performances for West Zone showed that his white-ball skills could translate into first-class cricket. Gautam Gambhir, meanwhile, used the tournament as both a launchpad early in his career and a route back into India's Test side in 2016.

The list is long and revealing. The Duleep Trophy has often been where future India players first made a serious case for themselves.

Nobody is saying domestic cricket doesn't matter. It clearly does. But it has left many in the circuit wondering where sustained first-class performances fit into the equation. Last season's Ranji Trophy offered enough evidence to keep the debate going.

Karnataka's Smaran Ravichandran finished with 950 runs. Delhi's Ayush Doseja scored 949. Mumbai's Siddhesh Lad averaged over 77, while Bengal's Sudip Kumar Gharami produced

another prolific campaign, amassing 797 runs. Harsh Dubey continued his remarkable consistency with the ball. Auqib Nabi, after another outstanding season, finally earned his maiden India call-up.

For Rajasthan fast bowler Aniket Choudhary, the priorities have changed over the last decade.



Stars to watch out for in 2026 Duleep Trophy

Ishan Kishan (East Zone), Vaibhav Sooryavanshi (East Zone), Rajat Patidar (Central Zone), Ruturaj Gaikwad (West Zone), Mohammed Shami (East Zone), Karun Nair (South Zone), Mayank Agarwal (South Zone).

